Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art & Design

Programme Specification

1. General Information

Programme title:	Information Experience Design
Award:	Masters
Qualification Framework level:	Level 7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Communication
Campus location(s):	White City
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to:	2025-26

2. Programme Philosophy

Information Experience Design (IED) is the creative practice of intervening in, designing and generating experiences of complex ideas and phenomena using data and experience design. The shared medium in IED is information: students work with both "cold" data (quantifiable numeric data) and "warm" data (the data of interrelationship). This allows you to build exciting personal practice in living systems and computational systems.

Our teaching approach is unique and experimental, representing the cutting edge of art and design education and informed by world-class research by IED practitioners. This requires a high level of maturity and dedication from students. The pieces we make include large-scale installations, immersive digital experiences, radical performances, and living artefacts and ecosystems. Our purpose on the MA in Information Experience Design is to inspire experimental works that generate transformation, seek better futures through the generation of compelling experiences, compose better questions and new ways of relating to and being in the world.

The intellectual content of the programme is cutting-edge and challenging, with our staff and students continually working in ways that are research-led and self-critical, never content with superficial responses or easy answers. Complexity and deep structure often feature in IED approaches, as these lend themselves to interrogations of media-cultural interchange and processes of modelling futures. Students of IED engage deeply with society and the environment, where rigorous experimentation is integrated with forms of activism, empathy, and good ancestry.

Our approach to theory is wide-ranging and transdisciplinary, involving technologists, ecologists and quantum physicists alongside those working in the arts. Throughout, the programme aims for a criticality that does not take an objective or purist tone, but rather situates the artist and thinker as always already complicit in ongoing social and environmental processes, and we frequently leave the ivory tower and test ideas in the wild. Your work will be evaluated on technical construction as well as logical and ethical soundness, aesthetic dimensions as well as critical and philosophical ones.

In IED you might design a large-scale light installation in a forest, a distributed museum spanning the globe, a serial podcast fiction, a chair that breathes, a VR adventure in a microbiome, an

emotionally responsive game for dogs, or a wearable that senses deep time. IED projects are human(e) but not only for humans, and move beyond the personal and individual, reaching toward perspectives and approaches that are collective, transindividual, superpersonal, and have more-than-human value.

Technical instruction in IED is based on a plan that you design and our technicians support, thus you leave the programme with a composite technical skill set generated by and unique to your body of work. This may involve technical skills as diverse as ceramics and VR, botany and blockchain. You'll have a core aim of experimenting with a diversity of methods and approaches that cross boundaries between digital and analogue, toward composing a distinctive body of work that coheres by intention: what you aim to achieve in the world. You'll be encouraged to work playfully, with experts providing guidance as you stretch your abilities and explore the multisensory, material and immaterial, digital and analogue, "high" and "low" art forms.

Human civilization is learning, or attempting to learn, to operate more effectively within expanded temporal and spatial structures, to think holistically about the planet and more long-term about our role as 'good ancestors'. For this reason, you will be challenged to conceive ideas, speculatively or not, that might operate at multiple scales, from the micro to the planetary. Societies are now actively questioning the ways in which we define value and conceptualise human and nonhuman relations—a paradigm shift in which artists and philosophers are leading. To solve increasingly intense complex challenges, the world needs creative visionaries who can generate systems shifts. In IED this is by designing interventions that interrupt entrenched multilateral processes, and engage us with reality differently through disruptive experiences.

We promote an active community who are thoroughly ambitious in practice and research. Throughout the programme we will encourage you to be adventurous, to pose new or uncomfortable questions and answers through your work. In IED you will be part of an environment that is inclusive and post-disciplinary in nature, where there is plenty to read but no theoretical 'canon' and no correct way of thinking about creative practice, except to use whatever is available as creatively as possible. For this reason, we require no specific skill set or disciplinary background to join the programme, with students arriving from many different backgrounds.

3. Educational Aims and Outcomes of the Programme

Programme aims

The MA in Information Experience Design Experience aims to:

- Be the leading programme of its kind in the world;
- Produce adventurous practitioners with deep understanding of post-digital experience through a frame of selected emphasis;
- Generate a holistic understanding of the social and environmental implications of creative interventions;
- Create new academic and professional relationships with others doing similar work, research and study;
- Produce students with informed and nuanced understanding of contexts for their work;
- Develop a pragmatically-informed understanding of how IED experience fits into industries relevant to your practice, which includes attentiveness to the perspectives of different stakeholders;
- Develop confidence in contributing to knowledge production, enabling you to take critical and ethically informed positions;

- Develop an understanding of research and analysis, and the crucial role they each play in the refinement of practice;
- Prepare you to develop technical skills in an ongoing and integrated way, responding proactively to technical challenges and opportunities that arise;
- Cultivate emotional intelligence, as a key attribute of those who generate experiences for others;
- Encourage a balance between independent working and collaboration, through the formation of communities of practice and creative-professional partnerships;
- Balance global and planetary concerns with lived and situated experiences, encouraging work that engages with civic life, grounded histories and local communities and environments.

What will I be expected to achieve?

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your programme-specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Translate abstract issues into tangible design proposals, grounding projects with real-world social, cultural, technological, and economic issues;
- Adapt and combine appropriate concepts and vocabularies from appropriate intellectual frameworks to frame your conceptual approach, and engage actively in critical discourse.
- Construct a technical approach that exploits the aesthetic and functional possibilities of different tools and materials;
- Develop an individual practice-based and research-led approach that relates to the context within which you wish to practice;
- Construct relevant and meaningful ways of involving collaborators and audiences into your design and research processes;
- Compose presentations of your work for others, ensuring they make the subject engaging and legible to your audience.

4. What will I learn?

Curriculum Map

<table>
<tr><th>Term 1</th><th>Term 2</th><th>Term 3</th></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">Form & Method
(45 credits)</td><td>Making Worlds with Others
(15 credits)</td><td rowspan="3">Independent Research Project
(60 credits)</td></tr>
<tr><td>Situated Practice
(30 credits)</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">AcrossRCA (30 credits)</td></tr>
</table>

Programme Structure

Unit Title	**Term**	**Credit Value**
Form & Method	1	45
Situated Practice	2	30
Independent Research Project (IRP)	3	60
Making Worlds with Others (School-wide unit)	2	15
AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)	1&2	30

Please note, there are three **Independent Study** weeks included in your programme (one per term). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

Through the programme, you will gain a working knowledge of experimental post-digital and cultural systems theory and practice, and its influence in society at a variety of scales, and from a variety of perspectives. You will use this context to build your own conceptual tools and framings, illustrate and test these tools through creative practice. You will continually refine your approach, and select technical skills to develop that suit the precise pieces and experiences you wish to create. This will allow you to generate a body of work that has conceptual depth as well as technical skill.

You will develop a rich transdisciplinary knowledge base, including language and terminologies for engaging with critical intellectual and practical discussions, leading-edge theory, and influential and foundational works in post-digital and systems theory and practice, with emphasis in a chosen area. Throughout the programme you will be discouraged from looking for a 'correct' way of thinking about or generating meaningful work, or of doing the programme, but rather you will be encouraged to cross boundaries and design your own way. Likewise, your intellectual work will not draw from textbook readings, as this programme does not have a disciplinary boundary. Instead, with the input from your tutors and Field Collective, you will select many of your core texts yourself, and you might draw on readings and approaches from games, interaction design, critical theory, anthropology, speculative design, posthumanities, philosophy, ecology, literary studies, environmental

communication, and more. You will also be encouraged to engage with relevant contexts such as emergent technologies and platforms, media convergence, play, emerging forms of and views on intelligence, and experimentation in relation to social justice and change.

In **Form & Method**, you will be immersed in foundational and state-of-the-art practice and theory in experience design and intervention, and you will launch into a series of experiments in rapid making. Experimentation in this unit should be bold and playful, with the guiding aim of building understanding of the affordances of many conceptual and technical tools and reflecting on outcomes. Alongside practical experiments, by the end of this unit you will have proposed your aims, and drafted your concept summary and technical summary. These three things constitute the key proposition of your degree: what you wish to study and hope to create, why this is worth doing, and how you will do it.

Across **terms 1 and 2**, you will participate in **AcrossRCA**. This unit aims to support you to meet the challenges of a complex, uncertain and changing world by bringing you together to work collaboratively in cross-programme interdisciplinary teams. In your team you will develop a self-initiated themed project, informed by expertise within and beyond the College. These projects will challenge you to collectively use your intellect and imagination to address key cultural, social, environmental and economic challenges. In doing so, you will develop and reflect on the abilities required to translate knowledge into action, and help demonstrate the contribution that creative practices can make to our understanding and experience of the world.

In **Situated Practice**, you will refine and develop your signature practice through more refined and focused making, whilst developing a more in-depth understanding of how it fits into the landscape of contemporary art. During this term you hone skills related to analysis, audience awareness and collaboration. Your focus in this unit will be experimentation that is more specific and directed than in the previous term, now adapting what you have learned from broad experimentation to develop your practice in intentional ways. Where *Form & Method* was outward-oriented, *Situated Practice* is more inward-focused, requiring you to apply continuous critical analysis to your processes, to evaluate them with the support of your tutors, and to refine your technical and conceptual approaches so that these taken together are stable, coherent, and distinctive.

In **Term 2**, the **Making Worlds with Others** School-wide unit will allow you to work alongside students within and across the School. Working from the perspective of your individual practices and disciplines, you will develop a project that engages with others and/or creates mutual exchanges of ideas and understandings, with the intention to create critically engaged situations and/or outcomes resulting in convivial knowledge exchange. Through collaborative learning and making the unit will support you in understanding knowledge exchange and public engagement and how you are to situate your own practice in these territories. The unit will also ask you to question how socially engaged practice can contribute to cultural understanding, co-researching and co-creating methods for knowing with, not knowing about.

Your **Independent Research Project** will enable you to integrate your practice into a larger critical discourse, to reflect on its significance and to generate knowledge through a research piece and presentation. This unit challenges you to integrate your technical and conceptual processes into a single research project. It also requires you to reflect on the outcomes of your work in the first two terms, to trace its trajectory and consider the direction of your work in the future. Where earlier programme units focused on exploration and experimentation, this unit focuses on transformation: emphasising the wider relevance of your practice, drawing out its strengths, and exploring how it can generate evolution or revolution in the world.

You will engage with a variety of elements of exhibition design and production in Exhibition Practice sessions. These are largely practical and hands-on, concentrated especially around a public

presentation of work in the form of an interactive festival in term 3 which is led and curated by students.

5. How will I learn?

You will apply a practical and intellectual method involving iterative stages of **exploration, experimentation, evaluation, and transformation** within projects and across the programme as a whole. With the support of tutors, you will author your own version of the programme through the proposal and refinement of key elements, including your proposed aims, concept summary and technical summary, which will guide you through a range of subject material.

By the middle of the first term, you will describe your **aims,** which relate to a real-world challenge or theme that you feel passionately about. This may be practical, cultural, social and/or existential. Your emphasis will be refined as your progress in the programme, guiding and situating your practice.

You will be supported in developing your practice in stages through the programme. In **Term 1**, you will focus on broad experimentation, producing a large number of studies, prototypes, and drafts as you diversify your technical skill set and determine what works best to express your ideas (your **method**). You will be encouraged to take risks, try hard, fail often, and draw insight from outcomes of your experiments. You will document these processes, discuss them with your colleagues and your personal tutor.

In **Term 2** you will focus on developing your individual practice, understanding this in relation to the practices of others, and negotiating your place in the wider field of experience design, often by bringing it into conversations with other subjects and topics. You might adapt and refine work you have created in **Term 1** or introduce a new variation on ideas you're exploring. Again, you will document your process and engage others with your work-in-progress.

In **Term 3**, you will reflect on your work critically and in context, as you make a case for its contribution to the 'state of the art' in experience design. Alongside this, you will be refining your concept for presentation and framing your work for your intended audiences, for example as an exhibition piece.

Your contact with tutors and technicians is likely to be most intensive at the start of the programme, and to be less in your final term as you work more independently on your final project. Your cohort will have a rhythm of intensive and contact-driven periods, matched by lower contact periods for deep attention and focus on your practice. You will have the support of your personal tutor through the programme. You will also have the support of your community of peers, with our students actively engaged in **Field Collectives**.

Field Collectives are home groups formed early in the programme, linked by an area of focus or emphasis. These are described as 'field' collectives to express dynamic processes of fields, as opposed to subjects or disciplines. Collectives are the spaces where you will engage in discussion, analyse texts, conduct experiments, show work, provide critique, and exchange knowledge on the most regular basis. Examples of fields might be Nonhuman Perspectives and Multispecies Design, Regeneration and Circularity, World-Building, or Artificial Intelligence. The field provides a frame through which to engage with experience design. Each Collective will be led by tutors who bring expertise relevant to the area, who will set the structure of sessions and assign readings and tasks.

IED has an annual cycle of lectures, seminars and workshops, drawing on the expertise of our community of staff, alumni, friends and colleagues in other institutions and organisations, whose work or ideas are particularly relevant to our concerns on the programme. This sets a tone for the

programme, providing a core set of ideas, challenges and approaches to inform your work, individually and collectively, through engagement with compelling voices. These may be artists, writers, scholars or thinkers with significance to relevant contemporary theory and practice who may be internal or external to the Royal College of Art's (RCA's) immediate network. This is an annual cycle that is embedded within all three programme units.

Technical development is highly student-led in IED. You will have access to **Technical Workshops**, negotiated technical sessions with technicians, and many materials housed in the RCA's online database of instruction. **Workshops** offer an intensive learning experience focused on a particular creative approach or technique. These might include technical instruction relevant to moving image, spatial design, gaming, physical computing or any other mode useful for you that is offered by the College. It may also include workshops related to presentation, designing portfolios, or other practical professional development skills. **Inductions** are activities that enable you to use technical facilities safely and, when appropriate, without supervision. **Negotiated learning** refers to sessions that you set up individually with technicians, to get one-to-one advice on your project needs and development goals.

You will engage with a variety of elements of exhibition design and production in **Exhibition Practice** sessions. These are largely practical and hands-on, concentrated especially around a public presentation of work in the form of an interactive festival in term 3 which is led and curated by students, and focus on specific project management skills as well as installation and build, planning and relationships, site management, Health and Safety, etc. There may be remote sessions on some topics where this is useful. These may also cover non-traditional exhibition formats.

In IRP, you will have **Research Intensive** sessions, which will support you in your research, analysis and written composition process, and allow you to discuss and address technical and conceptual challenges in a group. These may address important topics in a lecture-style format, but seminar and discussion are the focus.

You will have a **Personal Tutor**. This is a supportive relationship, and each meeting with your tutor has the aim of supporting your academic work, and assessing your progress in a continuous way.

Facilities: Depending on demand, studios may need to be booked in advance. All students have access to software licenses whether remote or on-site. Study in IED will, appropriately, happen in a **blended** way, meaning parts of this programme will be on-campus and parts will be online. This will be planned with College schedules and external factors in mind.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations
Regulations for assessment and progression can be found here. Please note that College regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments.
Unit assessment
In programme-specific units, we assess your work in a way that is ongoing, iterative and conversational rather than solely outcome-focused. This is to encourage a greater amount of risk taking and ambition in your approach, where unsuccessful experiments are considered part of the process and are valued in assessment. We also do this to ensure you are able to respond to feedback and integrate this at several points before your final mark is determined for a unit. This mode allows assessment to be a conversational process supporting you in confidently submitting final outcomes.

Assessment points do not aim to review your ongoing practice as a finished piece, but as a perpetual work-in-progress. Assessments require you to represent your work at given points in a way that is high-quality and clearly articulated. Assessments in IED do not require you to have reached an end point, but do require a high spec of representation and demonstration of your ongoing work. Your final assessment in IRP is the most 'final' of all assessments, where the submitted work should illustrate your signature practice in the strongest way possible.

Assessment of your submitted outcomes is crucial to retaining a rigorous approach to marking based on quality, and the feedback you receive from the panel will include attention to both elements.

Your ongoing meetings with your personal tutor will inform your final assessment on the unit. Ahead of each meeting, you will submit a short, written report reflecting on and documenting your progress and identifying challenges you would like to discuss. The aim is to track progress against learning outcomes in a transparent way, and to identify challenges and areas where you need support, as well as areas where the work may be faltering and require more dedication. The progress reports will be submitted once a term and retained for examination panel discussions. Your overall summative mark for the unit will be determined by your achievement of the learning outcomes, as demonstrated through your submitted outcomes

Your term 3 final outcome (submitted IRP) will be considered along with your final presentation and viva voce.

At the end of each programme-specific unit, an assessment panel will discuss your outcomes and the ongoing progress, and confirm your summative assessment mark for the unit, as well as providing written feedback.

Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the unit descriptors, and will be available to students at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What award can I get?

To be awarded an RCA MA degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units.
If you do not pass a unit at the first attempt, you may be offered an opportunity to resit the unit. If you are successful at resit you will be awarded the credits for that unit. If you are unsuccessful, you cannot progress further in your programme.

Exit awards:
If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7 of the FHEQ, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma. An exit award is a final award from the College and cannot be rescinded.

For more detailed information about the College's assessment, progression and awards policies see the Regulations.